Martin Newkirk

Product + Builder | Founder | Clean Energy & Mobility | Ex-Uber

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Neara · Strategy & Operations, Generalist track · Sydney

Dear Neara team,

I'd like to apply for the Generalist track of Strategy & Operations in Sydney. I was a Senior Associate in Strategy & Operations at Car Next Door through its acquisition by Uber, and I now run product at Photonik, the solar design software I co-founded. In both roles my best work has been embedded with a team, building rather than presenting.

The grid is where the energy transition gets exciting, and I've seen that from the rooftop. At Photonik I built models for home electrification and bidirectional EV charging: solar charging the car, the car powering the home, and both feeding the grid. Once you model it, a home stops being just a load and starts working with the network. At scale, that means utilities planning for power flowing both ways, through harsher weather, across their whole network. Neara gives them that view, and I want to help it deliver.

Your ad describes what good Strategy & Operations work looks like, and I've done it before.

At Car Next Door every car needed a hardware installation before it could join, and that capped our growth. I led Key Swap, which let owners join without one. When utilisation dipped early on, we rebuilt the operation around it: self-install kits, removing cars that didn't earn, and a path to full installation for the best owners. By the Uber acquisition, 60% of our 10,000 cars used it.

In 2023 I built the complaints system we needed to meet AFCA's requirements under Uber's scrutiny, from policy and escalation to reporting and frontline training. Through the acquisition I also ran company OKR planning and monthly executive reviews.

I'm comfortable getting technical. I rebuilt Photonik in six months with AI-assisted development: a Django and Angular platform on geospatial data, with more than 2,100 installer businesses signed up. Photonik has always been a side project. For the past 18 months I've had the chance to run it full time, and it will go back to being one.

Most of my customers have been consumers and small businesses rather than utilities, so I'd learn enterprise sales from your Sales and CS teams. What I'd bring is the operating side: keeping a complex delivery on track when much of it sits with other people.

I'm returning to Sydney in January. I can start remotely on two weeks' notice, then work from the Redfern office. Thank you for considering my application.

Kind regards,

Martin Newkirk